

Hungry schools

The swarms of small animals that form the zooplankton are preyed upon by fish such as anchovy, sardine, and herring. They swim in schools of thousands of fish, all moving together as if they were a single giant creature. Swimming like this helps them catch their tiny prey, and also makes the fish less easily caught by their own enemies.

SAFETY IN NUMBERS

Fish that live in open water near the surface can often find plenty to eat, but they are in serious danger of being eaten themselves. Big fish can take the risk, but smaller ones like these herrings swim in large schools. If attacked, a fast-moving, swirling school is a confusing target for a predator such as a shark or tuna; it is harder to isolate and catch a single fish.



SLEEK ENEMIES

Small plankton-eating fish are attacked by other schooling fish such as these mackerel, which seize them and swallow them whole. Mackerel in particular have highly streamlined bodies for fast swimming, and streak through the oceans at speed in search of big schools of prey fish. They also catch smaller prey by swimming with their mouths open to filter animals from the water.

FILTER FEEDERS

A fish "breathes" by gathering oxygen from the water, which flows into its mouth and through oxygen-absorbing gills at the back of its head. Plankton-feeding fish use their gill rakers to strain the water for prey as they swim through plankton swarms with their mouths wide open. The trapped prey is concentrated in the back of the fish's mouth and passes down its throat and into its stomach.

